The key to the Vikings' success was their ability to concentrate forces at an unexpected point with a rapidity of movement far superior to that of the defenders. When they sailed their longships across the North Sea or along the coastline, they could land wherever they chose, grounding their vessels on a stretch of beach. Although the Franks and Anglo-Saxons built watchtowers to look out for Viking raiding parties, they rarely had time to mount a significant armed response. On occasions when Vikings needed to make a rapid escape, they benefitted from the design of their ships, which had a prow at each end and could therefore be relaunched without being turned around. When Vikings penetrated inland up rivers, their progress was slower, with much use of oars and possibly the need to move the ships for short distances on land around shallows or other obstacles. This gave the defenders a better chance to organize an army to meet them. With around 50 men in each ship, however, and probably between 100 and 200 ships involved in a major attack such as that on Paris in 845, the Vikings had a good chance of matching any force that could be mustered to halt their progress.



Badge of loyalty
Leaders of Viking warbands would sometimes reward an especially loyal follower with a heavy silver armlet. If the warrior subsequently fell on hard times, he could snap off pieces of silver when required.

GANGING UP

The basic fighting force in Viking raiding warfare was the warband, a gang of adventurers attracted to the service of a warrior of proven courage and ability. Young men without prospects and keen for action would compete for admission into a successful warband. Proving yourself fierce, ruthless, and fearless in action would win you acceptance within the group and also, eventually, promotion to the warband leader's inner circle. The leader, for his part, had to provide action and plunder if he was to hold the loyalty of his followers and stave off competition from other warbands. Annual raiding expeditions kept up the supply of loot off which the men lived and satisfied their craving for excitement – for there can be no doubt that the Vikings thrived on the thrill of combat and enjoyed the thorough-going rape and massacre in which they indulged when given a chance. In the absence of outsiders to attack, Viking warriors would fight one another. Challenges to single combat were apparently common, either to settle issues of status or simply so that the winning fighter could claim the loser's property.

From out of nowhere
The first reported Viking raid on Britain was the sacking of the monastery at Lindisfarne in 793. The attack came completely without warning.